

FOREBODING CLOUD AND DIM STAR

Venith came to Terra, and the ground shifted beneath him, with the weight of stone and the attention of a being who saw all that lived upon it. Terra watched him with eyes older than mountains, patient, immovable, yet alive with thought, with worry, more worry than the others. Venith knelt, and the soil beneath his hands whispered, the trees leaned in, the rivers flowed with hidden currents of their master's gaze, and he spoke.

"Oh mighty one, keeper of the lands, guardian of stones and rivers, hear me! Look upon your creation, and see the folly of mortals. See how they fellow the soil and then poison it, how they cut and burn and drain, how they build and crush and take without care. Look upon their cities, their farms, their machines, and see how they wound you. Where once there was a field of deer, now there is the cobble of dirty roads. Give me the means to aid you, to protect your works, to shield your earth from the foolishness of men."

Terra looked long, their ancient gaze sweeping across the valleys, the hills, the people, and for a moment doubt touched them. And then Terra felt it — the urgency, the fear, the trees cut, the rocks destroyed, the fires, the destruction. For all living things were under her domain - but she could see one had grown too powerful, but she could not bear to stop them.

And so Terra gave away one of their gifts: the memory of the land. He could twist the path of the lumberjack into the dangerous forest, to show the hunter tracks where there had been none, to make beings that kept the sacred lake safe from outsiders, to shape the clouds and stars to slow the mortals. Nature would always be her domain, but maybe this one could change the memory of the grass to make it remember it was sharp.

Venith smiled at this gift, and then next went to Entropy.

— Spell, *Venith's Grand Lie*